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Oak Park residents to be John Kerry delegates

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Three residents from Oak Park: Oren Gabriel, 18, a senior at Oak Park High School; his mother, Judith Katzburg; and David Ettinger have been elected to be delegates for U.S. Sen. John Kerry (D-Mass.) at the Democratic National Convention in Boston next July.

The three were elected at the Feb. 8 John Kerry Caucus for Congressional District No. 24, which was conducted at Temple Adat Elohim in Thousand Oaks.

There were 15 candidates at the caucus who wanted to be Kerry delegates. Gabriel, the youngest of all, came in first among the men and second place overall after giving a speech about the importance of 18-to-21-year-old voters participating in the political process. His mother, Katzburg, finished in first place after voicing her concerns about access to healthcare in the U.S.

Ettinger finished with one less vote than the young Gabriel. Ettinger spoke about the importance of Democrats uniting their "temporary rivals" for the good of the party.

Gabriel, the senior class president at OPHS, recently visited Sacramento with the YMCA's California State Youth and Government program.

He was a state finalist for the Wendy's High School Heisman Trophy, a national award honoring students in athletics, academics and citizenship. In addition to his involvement in soccer and track, Gabriel volunteers and is student manager at the Westmin-ster Free Clinic in Thousand Oaks (which provides medical care to the working poor, uninsured and the homeless).

In his speech, Gabriel said, "As a delegate to the Democratic National Convention, I vow to involve my peers and bring them into the democratic process." Gabriel has already fulfilled that vow: many of his friends who never thought about politics have registered to vote. His experience at the free clinic, Gabriel said, was one of the factors that motivated him to support Kerry, the candidate who wants to see at least 94 percent health insurance coverage for Americans.

Healthcare is something dear to Gabriel's heart and it seems to run in the family. Katzburg, his mother, and the delegate with whom he's likely to travel, is a registered nurse with a master's degree in public health and a doctorate in health services research.

Katzburg is currently conducting research at UCLA and also volunteers as a nurse at the Westminster Free Clinic. She aligned herself with Kerry for the same reason as her son.

About being a delegate, she said, "This is another way to make changes."

Katzburg and her husband, Stuart Gabriel, a professor at USC, have lived in Oak Park since 1992. They also have a 22-year-old son, Jesse Gabriel, who's a senior at Berkeley studying political science.

Ettinger, a civil appeals attorney who's argued 10 cases before the state Supreme Court, has been involved in politics since he was young. He remembers passing out buttons for Eugene McCarthy when he was 12. He decided to run as a delegate after receiving an e-mail suggesting that he get involved. He sees Kerry as a responsible candidate who's intelligent and shows effective judgment and courage. Ettinger said he agrees with Kerry's environmental positions.

Ettinger has lived in Oak Park since 1988 with his wife, Susan, daughter, Rachel, 20, and son, Steve, 18.

Kerry must capture 15 percent or more of the votes in this Congressional District to be entitled to delegates in Boston.

If no other candidate gets 15 percent, Kerry will be entitled to have all of his delegates from the district. The primary election is next Tuesday.

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